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Philosophy of Politics:
Fascism in Italy: state, leader and
corporativism

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Fascism in Italy: State, Leader and Corporatism

- Construction of the Fascist state
- Mussolini and the principle of leadership
- Party, state and society
- Corporatism as an alternative model of representation
- Central question: *How did Italian Fascism attempt to transform political and social conflict into organized national unity?*

From Movement to Regime

- Mussolini became prime minister in October 1922
- Fascism initially operated within existing constitutional institutions
- Between 1925 and 1926, authoritarian transformation accelerated
- Political pluralism was progressively eliminated
- Fascism moved from capturing government toward restructuring the state

The Fascist Transformation of the State

- Strengthening of executive authority
- Weakening of parliamentary control
- Suppression of organized political opposition
- Integration of Fascist institutions into the state
- Construction of a new relationship between state and society

From Prime Minister to Head of Government

- The 1925 reforms strengthened Mussolini's institutional position
- The prime minister became the ****Head of Government****
- Parliamentary oversight of the executive was substantially weakened
- Executive authority increasingly became the center of the political system
- The institutional order was reorganized around political leadership

The Fascist Conception of the State

- The state is not merely an instrument for protecting individual rights
- It represents an organized political and national community
- Social interests should exist within the state rather than independently of it
- Political authority should produce unity from social diversity
- The liberal distinction between state and civil society is substantially weakened

The Ethical State

- Giovanni Gentile provides an important philosophical foundation
- The individual develops within a historical political community
- State and individual are not conceived as fundamentally opposed
- The state expresses an ethical conception of collective life
- Political membership involves duties as well as claims

State and Individual

- **Liberalism:** the state must respect an autonomous individual sphere
- **Fascism:** the individual acquires political meaning within the national community
- Individual interests are subordinate to collective national purposes
- Rights cannot automatically stand against the state
- The disagreement concerns the nature of political freedom itself

State and Nation

- Fascism closely connects state and nation
- The nation is not simply a population living within borders
- It is presented as a historical and political community
- The state gives institutional form to this community
- National unity becomes a fundamental political objective

The Problem of Political Pluralism

- Liberal politics assumes legitimate disagreement
- Multiple parties represent competing political interests
- Fascism interprets party competition as fragmentation
- Political unity should replace competition among organized interests
- *Can disagreement be eliminated without eliminating political freedom?*

The One-Party State

- Opposition parties were eliminated
- The National Fascist Party became the dominant political organization
- Independent political competition disappeared
- Party institutions became increasingly connected with state institutions
- The distinction between party and state became progressively blurred

The Fascist Grand Council

- Initially developed as a leading institution of the Fascist movement
- It later became a formal institution of the state
- It connected party leadership with constitutional government
- Important constitutional matters came within its remit
- Fascism therefore institutionalized the party within the state

The Problem of the Leader

- Fascism emphasizes political unity
- But unity requires authoritative direction
- Leadership is presented as more than ordinary administration
- The leader interprets and articulates national purposes
- Mussolini increasingly becomes the symbolic center of the regime

Mussolini as *Il Duce*

- *Duce* means leader
- Mussolini's political persona became increasingly central to Fascist legitimacy
- Propaganda presented him as energetic, decisive and indispensable
- Political authority became increasingly personalized
- The cult of *Il Duce* was a distinctive feature of Italian Fascism

Leader and Institutions

- Fascist leadership did not eliminate institutions
- Party, bureaucracy, monarchy, military and corporations continued to exist
- Mussolini operated through and between these institutions
- Fascist government therefore combined personal leadership with institutional complexity
- *Personal dictatorship and bureaucratic government could coexist*

Leadership and Representation

- Liberal representation works through electoral competition
- Fascism rejects competing parties as expressions of fragmentation
- Leadership is presented as expressing national rather than partisan interests
- The leader claims a direct relationship with the political community
- Representation becomes identification rather than electoral competition

Mass Politics Without Pluralism

- Fascism sought politically mobilized citizens
- Mass rallies and public rituals
- Party organizations
- Youth and occupational organizations
- Participation was encouraged within structures controlled by the regime

Consent and Coercion

- Fascist rule cannot be understood through repression alone
- The regime also sought popular participation and identification
- Propaganda and political ritual constructed images of national unity
- At the same time, organized opposition was suppressed
- Fascist rule combined *mobilization, incorporation and coercion*

Organizing Society

- Fascism sought to organize social groups rather than leave them autonomous
- Workers
- Employers
- Youth
- Professionals
- Economic interests were increasingly incorporated into state-supervised structures

Why Corporatism?

- Industrial society produces competing economic interests
- Liberalism permits organized competition among them
- Marxism interprets them through class struggle
- Fascism seeks their integration into national political unity
- Corporatism becomes the proposed institutional solution

What Is Corporatism?

- Economic society is organized according to occupational and productive functions
- Workers and employers belong to recognized organizations
- These organizations are integrated into a state-supervised system
- Functional representation replaces unrestricted interest competition
- The state claims ultimate authority over the system

The Corporative Principle

- Society consists of differentiated productive groups
- These groups have distinct interests
- Their conflict should not determine political life
- The state coordinates them toward national objectives
- **Difference is preserved, but political autonomy is restricted**

Against Liberal Economic Individualism

- Fascism rejects the idea that economic life is purely private
- Private property can remain
- Private enterprise can remain
- But economic activity is interpreted as having a national function
- The state claims the right to intervene when national interests require it

Against Marxist Class Struggle

- Fascism rejects proletarian internationalism
- Employers and workers should not understand themselves primarily as antagonistic classes
- Both are members of the same national community
- Economic conflict should be institutionally mediated
- *Class collaboration replaces class struggle*

The Rocco Laws

- Legislation beginning in 1926 reorganized labor relations
- Independent trade-union pluralism was eliminated
- Fascist unions received official recognition
- Strikes and employer lockouts were prohibited
- Labor conflict became subject to state regulation

The Charter of Labour

- *Carta del Lavoro*, 1927
- Important statement of Fascist social and economic principles
- Private enterprise remained part of the economic system
- Production was framed as a matter of national interest
- State intervention was legitimate when political or economic objectives required it

Private Property Under Fascism

- Fascism did not abolish private property
- Private enterprise remained important
- Property was not treated as absolutely autonomous from political authority
- Economic activity was expected to serve national purposes
- Fascist economics therefore differed from both laissez-faire liberalism and communist social ownership

The “Third Way” Claim

- Fascist corporatism presented itself as an alternative to two systems
- Liberal capitalism: competition among private interests
- Marxism: class struggle and social ownership
- Fascism: private property coordinated through state authority
- Corporatism was promoted as a distinctively Fascist solution

Corporations

- Corporations were formally instituted in 1934
- They brought together representatives connected to employers, workers, party and state
- They were organized around sectors of economic activity
- They were intended to coordinate economic interests
- Their practical influence was more limited than Fascist doctrine suggested

Representation Without Parties

- Fascism sought an alternative to territorial parliamentary representation
- Individuals would be represented through their social and economic functions
- Producer rather than autonomous voter becomes politically important
- Corporative representation promises to connect state and organized society
- Political pluralism is replaced by functional representation

The Chamber of Fasces and Corporations

- Established in 1939 to replace the Chamber of Deputies
- Membership was not based on competitive parliamentary elections
- Position within Fascist and corporative institutions determined membership
- The reform institutionalized corporative representation at the national level
- It marked a further departure from liberal parliamentarism

Guido Bortolotto: The Corporative State

- *Dottrina del Fascismo* (1939)
- Fascism presented as an integrated political doctrine
- Corporatism connects economic organization with political authority
- Social groups become components of a larger political order
- The state remains superior to particular interests

Bortolotto: Hierarchy and Authority

- Political society requires organization and direction
- Different institutions perform different functions
- Authority coordinates those functions
- Hierarchy prevents competing interests from fragmenting political unity
- Political order therefore takes precedence over unrestricted social autonomy

Corporatism: Theory and Practice

- **Theory:** harmonization of labor and capital
- **Theory:** functional representation of productive interests
- **Theory:** overcoming both class conflict and parliamentary fragmentation
- **Practice:** corporations remained subordinate to the Fascist state
- Their actual policymaking role was substantially more limited than ideological claims implied

State Intervention and the Economy

- Fascist Italy retained substantial private ownership
- State intervention nevertheless expanded
- The economic crisis of the 1930s strengthened public involvement
- Public institutions acquired significant roles in banking and industry
- Fascist economic practice cannot therefore be reduced simply to corporative theory

The Limits of the Fascist State

- Fascist claims of complete political unity exceeded institutional reality
- The monarchy survived
- The Catholic Church retained significant autonomy
- Traditional bureaucratic and economic elites remained important
- Local institutions and interests complicated central control
- The Fascist state was powerful but not institutionally monolithic

State and Church

- The Lateran Pacts of 1929 resolved the long-standing “Roman Question”
- The Vatican City became a sovereign entity
- Relations between the Italian state and Catholic Church were formally regulated
- The settlement strengthened the regime's political position
- It also demonstrated that important institutions continued to exist outside direct Fascist control

Three Pillars of Fascist Political Organization

- **State:** institutional expression of national unity
- **Leader:** direction and personification of political authority
- **Corporatism:** organization of social and economic interests
- Together they offered an alternative to liberal parliamentary representation
- Their common objective was the political integration of society

Fascist Theory and Institutional Reality

- Doctrine emphasizes unified political authority
- Institutions remained more complicated and fragmented
- Doctrine emphasizes harmonious corporative cooperation
- Economic and social conflicts persisted
- The gap between ideological model and institutional practice is essential to understanding Fascist Italy

Questions for Discussion

- Can functional representation replace electoral representation?
- Does corporatism resolve class conflict or politically suppress it?
- Can a state genuinely represent a single national interest?
- What happens when leadership becomes a source of political legitimacy?
- Where does civil society end when social organizations become instruments of the state?

The Fascist State

- Mussolini/Gentile: *Can the state embody an ethical political community?*
- Mussolini: *Can leadership overcome parliamentary fragmentation?*
- Bortolotto: *Can hierarchy organize society into a coherent political whole?*
- Corporatism: *Can labor and capital be integrated through state authority?*
- Fundamental question: *Can political unity be institutionally constructed without eliminating the autonomy and pluralism of society?*